

Title PL Russia-Aligned Operation Overload Targets Polish Elections

13/05/2025

Summary

- At the end of April there was a peak of Operation Overload accounts targeting presidential elections in Poland, mostly sharing claims of terrorist threat around the vote. Content, which impersonates media and official sources, was shared on X and Bluesky, and in one instance its origin was traced to a Russian pro-Kremlin Telegram channel.
- The meta-narrative was that Polish government is unable to guarantee election security; sub-narratives included allegations of corruption and censorship; Ukrainian refugees were portrayed as a security threat to Poland.
- Seven posts available as of May 8 garnered more than 840,000 views, however the likes and shares of these posts were mostly inorganic, driven by a coordinated network of accounts. Although at the moment the impact of the campaign seems limited, it might become more significant if the content is picked up by authentic accounts with large followings. At the time of writing, May 12, only three posts remain available and other accounts have been suspended.
- Key objectives appear to be to undermine trust in Polish institutions and dissuade citizens from voting in the election because of an alleged terrorist threat. These are similar [to those noted](#) in Operation Overload content targeting Germany ahead of the federal election in February.
- TTPs included use of impersonated personas, deceptively edited content and bot amplification.
- More pressure needs to be put on platforms to take down false content and coordinated networks involved in its amplification; Media and other organisations should be made aware that they have been targeted by the campaign.

Incident

Between March 23 and April 28, Operation Overload published at least 10 pieces of content targeting Poland on X. On April 22, a spike in activity of Operation Overload accounts was detected, with seven posts on X related to presidential elections in Poland. Most of these posts insinuate a terrorist threat to the elections (see [here](#), [here](#) and [here](#)), claim that the number of Polish police present at the polling stations will be [half of that in 2020](#), and sharing fake news about a [Ukrainian refugee](#) arrest for plotting poison gas attacks in Warsaw on election day.

All posts were in English. At least [one piece](#) of Operation Overload content, alleging that the Polish presidential elections may be cancelled due to terrorist threats, was also cross posted on Bluesky. The origin of [another](#) post accusing the current Polish president of corruption, appears to be a Russian pro-Kremlin [Telegram channel](#), which confirms previous research findings about the Russian connection of Operation Overload. Three accounts that posted Operation Overload content have been suspended at the time of research (May 8), and another four by the time of writing this alert (May 12).

Operation Overload accounts impersonated mainstream Polish media such as RMF FM, Gazeta Wyborcza, TVP World, as well as prominent international media outlets (Financial Times, BBC, Zeit, Euronews, Politico, Economist), in an attempt to garner more credibility. In nine instances, videos bearing organisations' logos were overlaid with text captions attributing false claims to these organisations, journalists, officials and other well-known personalities. In one instance, an altered image of a media front page was used, along with a headline containing false information. Various media, government and fact-checking organisations were tagged in these posts, in a known Operation Overload tactic aimed at overwhelming organisations and provoking them to respond, verify and debunk false claims.

Narrative

Meta narrative: EU countries are unable to ensure election security

Sub-narratives: There is a serious terrorist threat to the presidential elections in Poland; the Polish government is unable to guarantee the security of elections; Poland's current government is corrupt and introduces censorship; Ukrainian refugees are a security threat to Poland.

Impact

The seven posts that were still available on May 8 garnered a total of 840,400 views and 5,058 engagements (reposts, replies, and likes). There is strong evidence that this engagement was inorganic and driven by a coordinated network of accounts. For 6 out of 7 posts, all of this engagement occurred within a single minute. With the remaining one, the activity occurred over the course of 31 minutes. Additionally, accounts engaging with the content exhibited other clear signs of inorganic activity. Many had 0 followers and had suddenly become active in recent months; 98% of their content were reposts in various languages, such as Spanish, Japanese, Arabic and English. Of the remaining 2%, the vast majority of original posts was a random mix of letters and numbers (and likely posted to seem less suspicious).

The impact was likely limited because the content remained largely confined to Operation Overload network of amplifiers and mostly failed to achieve organic spread. All engagements came within single minute increments or from accounts that were identified, as per above indicators, to be likely that same network of amplifiers. However, it is possible that some views out of 840,400 were from real users. There is a risk of real-life impact in the event of Operation Overload content being picked up by prominent X users with large followings, something [that has happened before](#).

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective 1: T0135 – Undermine: Undermine trust in Polish government and law enforcement institutions by portraying them as unable to guarantee election security and corrupt; polarise Polish society by promoting negative sentiment towards Ukrainian refugees.

Objective 2: T0139 – Dissuade from Acting: Discourage citizens from participating in presidential elections by stoking fears of a terrorist threat.

T0143.003 – Impersonated Persona: Impersonating legitimate media outlets and personalities to increase legitimacy.

T0023.001 – Reframe Context: Use existing content, alter it and add false claims.

T0086.003 – Deceptively Edited Images: Altered frontpage of a prominent media with a false headline to deceive audiences.

T0049.003 – Bots Amplify via Automated Forwarding and Reposting: A coordinated inorganic network of amplifiers on X was driving engagement, with most content reposted within a minute.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Continued monitoring of Operation Overload activity targeting Polish elections.

Recommendations: Insist on platforms taking down false content and coordinated networks involved in its amplification; Raise awareness with media and other organisations targeted by the campaign.

Report	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
n/a	Russia/Russia-aligned	Upon request	Olga Tokariuk, ISD	X, Bluesky, Telegram	